

she could afford. In time, Maria became her family's main breadwinner as a catering manager for a large hotel. Because of Maria, her family had a comfortable life and she was proud to help provide it for them.

After seven years, Maria started feeling more at home in Los Angeles than in the Philippines. During her infrequent trips home, she would brag about how the United States was a land of opportunity, with jobs available for anyone who was willing to work. This picture she painted was appealing to some of her relatives who were struggling to find employment in the Philippines. Several decided to move to Los Angeles to share in the wealth.

Maria was more than willing to be their mentor when they arrived. She helped them find employment and let them stay with her until they got settled on their own. She even gladly cosigned on their loans and credit cards so they could establish credit. Because of Maria, her relatives were able to get credit cards, car loans, and even small business loans.

Three years later, when Maria entered the office for her credit counseling appointment, she was eight months pregnant and a nervous wreck. Not only had her boyfriend and father of her child decided to abandon her, but so had her relatives. Maria explained to the counselor that her relatives did not grow to love the United States like she had and decided to go back to the Philippines. They left behind large balances on their credit cards and unpaid loans. Maria was now being contacted by the lenders to pay these outstanding balances. Since she had cosigned on these loans, she was responsible for their payment even though her relatives were gone.

Maria's situation was even more desperate because her stress was affecting her health and possibly that of her unborn baby. Her doctors encouraged her to relax but it was hard because she received letters and daily phone calls from collectors. She did

